



ROY AGUILAR of Claremont heads up a hiking trail toward Mt. Baldy Resort on Saturday. The resort has been allowed to remain open.

On top of Mt. Baldy, a rebellion is brewing among defiant hikers

As 30-mph wind gusts howled across a flat spot known as “the notch” halfway up Mt. Baldy last weekend, three young men staggered down from the summit looking cold, tired and very excited to have just reached the highest point in Los Angeles County in such punishing conditions.

Not only had they braved the summit’s soaring altitude and fierce wind, they each also had risked a \$5,000 fine for violating a U.S. Forest Service closure order.

After a September wildfire ravaged Mt. Baldy Village, destroying 20 homes and burning more than 50,000 acres on sur-

rounding hillsides, the U.S. Forest Service closed all of the trails leading to the mountain’s breathtaking summit for more than a year — until December 2025 — to ensure public safety and promote “natural recovery” of the fragile plants and soils that had been damaged.

But had the three climbers, who ascended a trail called the Devil’s Backbone for its narrow ridge with spine-tingling drops on either side, seen any scorched earth or trees along the way?

“No, nothing at all, the trail was fine,”

GENARO MOLINA Los Angeles Times

By Jack Dolan

[See Mt. Baldy, A8]

A strategy to save a legacy of affordability

Nonprofit buys property to stave off gentrification in Cypress Park

By Doug Smith

For 15 years, it was a ritual that kept Andrés Cortes close to his beloved *abuelita*.

He would collect the rent from the other four tenants of her Cypress Park rental property, add his own and deliver the envelope in person to the family homestead a few blocks away.

She’d ask for news of the tenants by name and demure every time he told her they were willing to pay more.

“No,” she’d say. “I have enough.”

That unwritten contract expired late last year when the widowed Rufina Cortes died at 97. Her six children

faced the inevitable decision to put the five-unit property, in the family since the 1970s, up for sale.

The tenants needed a buyer who would be willing to sacrifice profit to keep the rents affordable.

But to buy the property at current market rates without jacking up rents, even an altruist would have to come up with some unlikely financial wizardry.

And it wasn’t altruists showing interest. Cortes and his partner, Claire Bernson, found themselves increasingly dismayed with a string of investors and developers brought through their one-bedroom cottage on the two-lot complex.

[See Cypress Park, A10]



CARLIN STIEHL For The Times

ANDRÉS CORTES and Claire Bernson, in the back alley of their home in Cypress Park, were dismayed with investors and developers looking to purchase it.

China planted agent in SoCal, U.S. says

Yaoning ‘Mike’ Sun of Chino Hills is charged with conspiracy and acting illegally for a foreign power.

By Hannah Fry and Richard Winton

The Chinese government allegedly used a Chino Hills man in an effort to advance policies favorable to the People’s Republic of China in Southern California local government, according to a criminal complaint released Thursday.

Yaoning “Mike” Sun, 64, was charged with acting as an illegal agent of a foreign power and conspiring with another man — John Chen — who had been plotting to target U.S.-based practitioners of Falun Gong, a spiritual practice banned in China. Chen was sentenced last month to 20 months in prison for acting as an unregistered agent of China and bribing an Internal Revenue Service agent.

Sun, a Chinese national, served as the campaign manager and business partner for a Southern California politician, described in court records only as Individual 1. The politician was running for local office in 2022.

During the campaign, prosecutors allege, Sun communicated with Chen about his efforts to get the politician elected to a city council. Chen relayed information to officials in the Chinese government about how it could influence local-level politicians in the United States, particularly in getting them to oppose Taiwan’s independence, according to the complaint.

U.S. Atty. Martin Estrada called the case “another example of a very disturbing trend” of the Chinese government seeking to influence foreign and domestic policies in the United States. China takes a broad approach, he said, including connecting with local government officials. Estrada said a goal of the scheme was to reduce “support in our country for Falun Gong and ... for pro-democracy movements in China.”

The scope of the effort and whether it led to any concrete actions to favor China is unclear.

But the indictment comes at a time of souring U.S.-China relations and a looming trade war as President-elect Donald Trump prepares to return to the White House.

There have been growing signs that China is attempting to influence U.S. politics.

[See Agent, A6]

Trapped between Trump and chaos

With government shutdown at risk, House speaker tries to meet demands and keep his job. **NATION, A5**

Bacteria strain raises alarm

Drug-resistant microbe found in L.A. County is worrying health experts. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Weather

Partly sunny and cooler. L.A. Basin: 66/46. **B6**

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Amazon strike hits California

Teamsters union leads warehouse workers’ efforts during holiday rush. **BUSINESS, A7**

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Trans government workers brace for Trump

Military officers, diplomats and others fear recent progress will be rolled back.

By Tracy Wilkinson

WASHINGTON — The Air Force lieutenant colonel left the Pentagon one day and returned the next — with a new name and a new

gender identity.

Bree Fram remembers the atmosphere in 2020 as welcoming and supportive. Her colleagues brought cookies. When the Pentagon officially changed her gender in employment records, she felt her journey was complete.

Fram is one of thousands of transgender people working openly in government positions, including in the Defense and State depart-

ments, intelligence agencies and various other federal branches. An estimated 15,000 transgender people work in the military alone. They say acceptance and support have surged in recent years.

But many are now worried that the broad advances they achieved over the last decade will be reversed under President-elect Donald Trump, who has likened gender transition to “muti-

lation,” vowed to roll back job protections and health-care for trans workers, and threatened to reimpose a ban on transgender people serving in the military.

“The mood among the community is apprehensive,” Fram said, noting she was speaking in her personal capacity and not on behalf of the Air Force.

Two transgender women in the State Department, [See Trans workers, A6]



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